

Understanding Your Treatment Options for Ectopic Pregnancy

What Is an Ectopic Pregnancy?

An ectopic pregnancy occurs when a fertilized egg implants outside the uterus, most commonly in a fallopian tube. Unfortunately, this type of pregnancy cannot continue and poses serious health risks if untreated, including internal bleeding and damage to reproductive organs.

Why Treatment Is Necessary

Without treatment, an ectopic pregnancy can rupture, causing life-threatening bleeding. Prompt diagnosis and care are critical. Fortunately, there are safe and effective options to treat it—medical management with methotrexate or surgical treatment.

Treatment Options

1. Medical Management: Methotrexate

What it is:

Methotrexate is a medication that stops cells from dividing and growing. It allows your body to absorb the pregnancy tissue over time.

Who it's for:

Stable vital signs

No signs of rupture or internal bleeding

Low and declining pregnancy hormone levels (hCG)

Ectopic mass is small and unruptured

No contraindications to the drug (e.g. liver or kidney disease)

What to expect:

Given as a single or multiple intramuscular injections

Requires close follow-up with blood tests (hCG levels checked every few days to ensure they're dropping)

You may have cramping, spotting, or light bleeding

Avoid alcohol, NSAIDs (like ibuprofen), and folic acid supplements during treatment

Pros:

No surgery or anesthesia

Preserves the fallopian tube

Outpatient treatment

Cons:

Takes longer for full resolution

Requires frequent monitoring and follow-up

Possible side effects: nausea, fatigue, mouth sores, abdominal pain

May not work in all cases (5–20% may need a second dose or surgery)

2. Surgical Treatment

What it is:

Surgical removal of the ectopic pregnancy, typically done through laparoscopy (minimally invasive surgery). In some cases, open surgery (laparotomy) may be necessary.

Types of surgery:

Salpingostomy: Removal of pregnancy tissue from the fallopian tube, leaving the tube intact

Salpingectomy: Removal of the entire affected fallopian tube (used if it's severely damaged or bleeding)

Who it's for:

Signs of internal bleeding or rupture

High or rising hCG levels

Contraindications to methotrexate

Failed medical therapy

Preference for a quicker resolution

What to expect:

General anesthesia is used

Usually performed as outpatient surgery

Recovery takes several days to a couple of weeks

Pros:

Quick resolution

Immediate removal of pregnancy

Option if medical therapy fails or isn't safe

Cons:

Risks of surgery: bleeding, infection, injury to nearby organs

May reduce fertility if a tube is removed

Future Fertility Considerations

Most women can go on to have healthy pregnancies after treatment. Your provider may recommend waiting 2–3 months before trying again after methotrexate, or until fully healed after surgery. If one fallopian tube is removed, the other can still support pregnancy. Discuss fertility concerns with your provider.

When to Seek Emergency Care

Go to the ER immediately if you have:

Severe abdominal or shoulder pain

Dizziness or fainting

Heavy vaginal bleeding

Rapid heartbeat

Final Thoughts

The choice between methotrexate and surgery depends on your specific condition, your medical history, and your goals for future fertility. Your provider will guide you through the safest and most appropriate option for you.